

the dazzlers and not the permanent blinders.

High-energy laser weapons refer to lasers generating several hundreds of kilowatts of continuous-wave laser power, or megawatts of pulsed power, and capable of causing a structural damage to hostile targets like aircrafts and missiles over ranges extending up to hundreds of kilometres. In some of the developed countries, a lot of development and experimental activities are going on for different types of high-power laser sources that can be converted into viable weapons to enhance the performance specifications and improve upon system interface and integration aspects.

Looking ahead

Laser was confined to premises of prominent research centres like Bell laboratories, Hughes research laboratories and major academic institutes like Columbia University in its early stages of development and evolu-

tion. However, it is no longer so more than five decades after Theodore Maiman demonstrated the first laser in May 1960 at Hughes research laboratories.

Laser, as coined by Gordon Gould in his notebooks, is a household name today. It is undoubtedly one of the greatest inventions of the second half of the twentieth century along with satellites, computers and integrated circuits. Laser, which was called an invention in search of applications in 1960s, continues to be so even today due to the unlimited application potential it holds. This explosive growth in laser applications has largely been backed by unique characteristics of laser as outlined earlier in the article.

Though there is an expanded use of laser and laser technology in commercial, industrial, bio-medical, scientific and military applications, the areas of its usage are multiplying and so are the applications in each one of

those categories.

Lasers have been used in the past and would continue to be used in the future for applications like materials processing in industries, diagnostics and therapeutics in medicine, range finding and target designation in defence, environment sciences, astronomy, plasma studies and spectroscopy in scientific and technological research. What would be watched with interest in the future is the gigantic growth in the field of laser technology in the form of newer wavelengths, more efficient and powerful lasers, and laser applications such as emergence of directed-energy laser weapons, laser-assisted propulsion and removal of space debris, and ultra-high-resolution imaging to open a whole new range of healthcare applications.

The story is not yet over. ●

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